

The Price of Freedom

Written by

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Based on 'Baylan Skoll' and 'Shin Hati', original
characters from Dave Filoni at Lucasfilm and seen in the
Ahsoka TV show.

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1 EXT. SPACE - EVENING

Outer space. A mostly barren planet swathed in a cold light hangs in the darkness. A sharp-looking, metal ship flies through the stars towards the planet.

2 EXT. SKY - EVENING

A more rickety ship tumbles through the sky. Smoke billows from its engines as it drops down past the treeline.

3 EXT. FOREST - EVENING

BAY (early 30s), a haunted yet strong-willed man, sits cross-legged in a small clearing. His palms rest against his knees. His eyes are shut tight, not a flicker of the relaxation that one would expect of meditation. Bay flinches as we hear shouts of pain and the sounds of lightsabers swinging.

4 INT. FORCE VISION - EVENING

The screen is black. Red and green lights swish sporadically. Bright explosions of blaster fire. The signs of a battle long ago. Heavy breathing permeates through the noise, but we don't know whose. Suddenly, a young girl's scream cuts through the cacophony.

5 EXT. FOREST - EVENING

Bay tilts his head, eyes still closed. He has relived his past over and over for years, but this is different. Bay furrows his eyebrows to hone in on the new sound.

6 EXT. FOREST - EVENING (VISION)

SHIN (15), JEYIN (40s), and two others race through the thick foliage. Roots yank at their feet and they stumble, but never stop moving. It is literally life and death. Shin's face is wet from a mix of sweat and tears. Her mother grips her hand tightly, terrified to let go for even a second. Surrounding Shin is a strange shadow. It pulses with power, keeping time with her fast, ragged breaths. A disembodied voice cuts through the vision.

NYX (O.S.)

Bay. Bay.

Shin's head whips around, looking straight into the camera as if she can sense Bay's eyes on her.

7 EXT. FOREST - EVENING

Bay's eyes snap open. A mercenary, NYX (late 20s), crouches down in front of him, a hand on Bay's shoulder. The man is rugged and confident, loyal when the payday suits him. Bay gulps in a deep breath, eyes still wide as if he is still in the vision.

NYX

Bay. Come on - we're unloading the ship. Captain wants us to make camp.

BAY

What about the escapees?

Nyx shrugs, a wicked smile growing.

NYX

They won't get far now it's getting dark. Besides, we can take our time with the hunt.

He slaps Bay's shoulder in a show of camaraderie. Bay gives him a shaky smile, still thrown off balance. Nyx walks away and begins to set up a makeshift tent. Bay pushes himself to his feet and approaches the edge of the clearing.

8 EXT. DENSE FOREST - EVENING

Shin races through the trees with her group. She is exhausted, but determined. Despite her years of fear and oppression, she is courageous and protects who she loves. Pulling her along is Jeyin, a woman who refuses to be trodden down by those who try to control her. Leading their ragtag gang of escaped prisoners are a man and a woman. VALA (30s) is a muscled, mean-eyed woman, but she has a soft heart. No matter how many horrors she has seen, she looks after her people. KRELLIS (30s) sees the good in others despite the evil he's been subjected to.

The group come to an open space. The trees are eerily still. Jeyin doubles over, hands on her knees as she sucks in desperate gasps of air. Vala and Krellis survey their surroundings and begin speaking in inaudible, hushed voices. Shin's breathing begins to even out. She tilts her head up and gasps. Above them, the sky is a watercolour portrait of oranges and purples. Stars have started to appear. She spins in a slow circle, taking it in.

She never thought she'd get to see the sky again. In fact, she can't remember a time she saw it.

VALA

Kid. Hey!

Shin snaps back to reality at the sound of Vala's urgent yet hushed voice.

VALA (cont'd)

Focus up. We've gotta keep moving, or have you forgotten we're being hunted.

Shin tightens her jaw and tears fill her eyes. Her mother rushes over and pulls her tightly into a hug. Jeyin shoots Vala a glare. Vala softens and exhales.

VALA (cont'd)

I'm sorry. That wasn't fair.

She crouches down and meets Shin's eyes.

VALA (cont'd)

I know you're scared. But I'll tell you something...me too.

Krellis watches on fondly. Jeyin smiles down.

VALA (cont'd)

But we have to keep going, okay? We can protect each other.

Shin's smile is fragile but genuine. She nods. Vala stands up and nods to Krellis. He points through the woods.

KRELLIS

If we keep heading this way, we'll get to Prodona just after first light. We'll make camp in a couple hours.

Jeyin shakes her head, her voice unsteady.

JEYIN

We shouldn't stop. If they catch up-

KRELLIS

(cuts her off)

Travelling at night gives them too much advantage. Trust me.

Though she doesn't like it, Jeyin defers to him. She squeezes Shin's shoulder one more time before the group takes off back into the thick, dark woodland.

9 EXT. FOREST - MERCENARY CAMP - EVENING

Bay ducks under a particularly low branch into a small, cramped clearing. A tarpaulin leans against a tree. Beneath it, a large, dog-like beast is curled up beside CAPTAIN JASU (40s), a powerful woman with a mean streak. She strokes her pet's head and it nuzzles into her hand. Bay kneels beside her. Jasu doesn't look up, instead keeping her worried eyes on the beast.

CAPTAIN JASU

She hasn't eaten since we landed on this hellish planet.

BAY

I think we have some emergency supplies on the ship.

Jasu shakes her head.

CAPTAIN JASU

She needs to hunt, a challenge. All that's here are small rodents.

She turns to him finally, a small, wicked grin spreading on her face.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)

Except for our prey, of course.

Bay tries to match her smile but it is strained. He's having doubts, not sure if he agrees with her any more.

BAY

Will she be okay for another day?

CAPTAIN JASU

She'll manage. We've been longer without a meal. Don't you remember Tatooine?

He lets out a little laugh. He and the beast lock eyes and immediately, it gets up and lays beside Bay instead.

BAY

I'm still getting sand out of places I didn't know existed.

They share a smile, sitting comfortably in the memory of missions past. Bay breaks the eye contact and shifts where he sits. Jasu looks up and calls through the trees.

CAPTAIN JASU
Gather round!

She lets out a sharp whistle and her pet returns to her side. The gang of mercenaries circle around the captain and kneel, attentive and obedient.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
The reports say that their ship crashed two clicks from here. The dampening fields used to protect the mines, stop ships flying over. We bed down tonight. Regular patrols. But they're not getting far now it's getting dark. So get some rest. Dismissed!

The mercenaries nod and disperse, chatting amongst themselves quietly. Bay looks out into the darkening forest, a crease forming between his brows.

10 EXT. FOREST - MERCENARY CAMP - NIGHT

The mercenaries sit around a campfire. The flames crackle and provide just enough light to see by. Yaslo deals from a deck of Sabacc cards as they laugh.

NYX
No, no you have got that absolutely wrong!

SHADA
We were all there, Nyx. We saw it!

The mercenaries talk over each other as Nyx protests indignantly. A mercenary, clad in armour with their blaster rifle in their hands, approaches. Nyx gestures at them.

NYX
Reya, will you please tell them what actually happened on that job back on Naboo?

The mercenary, Reya, takes off her helmet. Her hair tumbles over her shoulders as she gives Nyx a wry smile.

REYA FENN
I've done my whole patrol and you're still arguing about this?

Yaslo smiles at her.

YASLO BIS
Am I dealing you in?

Reya drops onto a log next to her comrades and leans her rifle next to her.

REYA FENN
I'm in.

Nyx raises his eyebrows expectantly at her.

NYX
Well? Are you going to stand up for me here?

She glances around at the mercenaries, smiling as she builds the tension.

REYA FENN
You definitely fell on top of him, Nyx!

Nyx points a finger at her.

NYX
No, I jumped to take him down. There's a huge difference.

Another from the group chimes in.

YASLO BIS
I saw you on the roof before it happened. You were looking in the complete wrong direction!

The group burst into raucous laughter. Nyx drops his head in mock-disappointment. The mercenary next to him slings an arm around Nyx's shoulders, jokingly scalding their friends.

SHADA
Come on, guys, leave him alone. Can't be upsetting Jasu's golden boy!

The laughter is even more raucous as Shada knuckles Nyx's hair. Nyx pushes him off, a reluctant smile forming on his lips.

NYX
Oh can it. We all know Bay's her right hand.

The mercenaries murmur in agreement. Nyx raises an eyebrow at his cards and the smile spreads.

NYX (cont'd)
Well let's get to playing, cause this
golden boy's about to take all your
credits.

The mercenaries laugh and chat as they look at their cards.

11 EXT. FOREST - ESCAPEE CAMP - NIGHT

Darkness has swallowed the woods. The silhouettes of trees shroud the small nook as our group of escapees settle into their makeshift camp. A dying fire glows in the middle, casting a faint orange light across Shin's dirt-smeared, exhausted face. She shivers a little. Behind her, Jeyin snores lightly, the only time she allows the pain to show on her face. She is pale and sweaty, a crease between her brows as she grimaces. Shin tosses and turns on the mulch-covered ground. She screws her eyes shut, desperate for sleep to take over. Instead, something else...

12 EXT. SAND DUNES - AFTERNOON (VISION)

She sees a hazy vision of a man we can't quite make out in Jedi robes as he stands on the top of a sand dune. He gazes out at the sea, lost in thought.

PALPATINE (O.S.)
The time has come. Execute Order
Sixty-Six.

The same screams resonate through the vision as we heard in the beginning. At the sound of a blaster, the man whips his head around. It is Bay, a few years younger and less haunted. Shin stands frozen to the spot in the vision, eyes wide in confusion. He appears to be looking right at her.

13 EXT. FOREST - MERCENARY CAMP - NIGHT

Bay shoots up from his bed roll with a gasp. He is drenched in sweat. His breathing is ragged as his eyes flick from side to side, trying to make sense of his dream vision. He runs a hand through his hair. He peers around at the tents in the mercenaries' camp. No one else has stirred. He pushes himself up and ducks under the tarpaulin into the crisp night air.

14 EXT. FOREST - MOMENTS LATER

Bay trudges through the trees as he tries to piece together his dream. He shakes his head, unable to make sense of it. He takes a deep breath and closes his eyes in an attempt to enter the vision again. He just hears Shin's scream again. He opens his eyes and drops onto a rock. He's found himself in the makeshift storage area, surrounded by crates and spare ammo boxes. He takes out his blaster and gazes down at it. The barrel resembles a lightsaber's handle...

Through the darkness, he focusses on a particularly hefty box of supplies. He gulps. He holds out a tentative hand towards it and narrows his eyes, focussing. At first, nothing happens. But then, the crate begins to rise shakily into the air.

NYX (O.S.)

(whisper)

Bay?

Bay jumps and drops his hand. The box drops back to the dirt with a thump. From the trees beside him, Nyx appears with his blaster rifle in his hands. He lets it drop to his side, hanging by the sling.

NYX

What are you doing out here?

Bay shoves his blaster back into its holster and stands. He attempts a nonchalant shrug.

BAY

Couldn't sleep. You?

Nyx lifts his rifle a little with one hand.

NYX

Patrol duty.

Bay nods.

NYX (cont'd)

(smiles)

Too excited?

Bay's eyes widen. He thinks Nyx knows about his vision and his doubts. He covers his panic with a furrowed brow.

BAY

About what?

NYX
(small exhale of a
chuckle)
Tomorrow. Catching up with those
slaves and getting paid obviously.

Bay breathes a sigh of relief but turns it into a laugh.

BAY
Oh yeah. Of course.

Nyx, still smiling, pushes Bay's shoulder in a friendly,
almost brotherly, way.

NYX
Can't keep our Bay from a good fight,
eh?

Bay just smiles at him. After a moment, he nods his head
back towards the camp.

BAY
Better try and get some rest.

NYX
Yeah, go on. Gotta finish my route or
Jasu will have my other eye.

They share another smile and go their separate ways.

15 EXT. FOREST - MERCENARY CAMP - LATER

Still unable to quiet his mind, Bay sits cross-legged in his
tent. His face is illuminated by a glowrod as he stares down
at his blaster once again. He runs a finger along the
barrel. Screams and shouts echo in his head. He takes a deep
breath and pulls on a cord around his neck. A small, leather
pouch on the end of a necklace emerges from beneath his
shirt. Bay pulls on it and the cord snaps. He opens the
pouch and pours the contents into the palm of his hand: a
small, jagged yellow crystal. He starts to take apart the
blaster, piece by piece...

16 EXT. FOREST - EARLY MORNING

The sun has only just begun to rise as Shin, Jeyin, Krellis,
and Vala pick their way through the forest. Jeyin winces and
holds her side. Shin narrows her eyes in concern, hurrying
up to Jeyin's side to help her walk.

SHIN
Mother - you're hurt?

A splodge of red she hadn't noticed before has seeped through Jeyin's scraggly top. The older woman straightens and puts on a brave face. She waves a dismissive hand at her daughter.

JEYIN

Don't worry, Shin. It's barely a scratch. Come on now - we don't want to lose the others.

Jeyin speeds up a little, though it is clearly difficult. Shin, still concerned, continues to lag behind. As Vala pushes aside a particularly large branch to allow the others to pass, she glances behind her and notices the young girl's expression. She slows down and walks beside Shin.

VALA

She'll be okay.

Shin keeps her eyes glued to the ground.

SHIN

She's hurt and...weak.

She looks up at Vala, eyes wide with admiration.

SHIN (cont'd)

Not strong - like you.

VALA

Hey.

Vala stops and drops to one knee. Shin stops and looks her in the eyes.

VALA (cont'd)

Jeyin is one of the strongest women I've ever met.

SHIN

But-

Vala places a firm hand on the young girl's shoulder.

VALA

You have to understand - your mother's been a slave most of your life, right? And even before that, she suffered, lost so much. But she has never once let you see her pain, has she?

Shin shakes her head silently.

VALA (cont'd)
Exactly. She is strong. Stronger than me. She never let it beat her. Never let them hurt you. Never gave up. Yeah, they might call me a warrior. But she's stronger in here.

She taps Shin's chest, right on her heart.

VALA (cont'd)
That sort of resilience doesn't come cheap. And she's passed that down to you. I can see it. So don't you ever underestimate her power. Or your own. Okay?

Shin nods with a small smile. Vala returns the expression and stands back up. She nods towards Krellis and Jeyin up ahead.

VALA (cont'd)
Come on.

Vala puts a gentle arm around Shin's shoulders as they catch up with Jeyin and Krellis.

17 EXT. FOREST - MOMENTS LATER

Vala and Shin walk in comfortable silence just behind Krellis and Jeyin. Shin looks up at her.

SHIN
How did you get there? The palace.

Vala purses her lips. She continues to push leaves and branches out of her way as they walk.

VALA
I was a scavenger. One day...Well, I ended up somewhere I shouldn't have been and someone grabbed me. Sold me to Hutt.
(sighs)
Apparently they decided I was strong enough to fight so they put me in the arena. For their entertainment.

She spits the last word as if it is venom.

VALA (cont'd)
That was about...five years ago, I think. It's hard to keep track.

Krellis calls over his shoulder.

KRELLIS

Six. Because I've been there for seven and it wasn't until after a year they realised I couldn't fight worth a damn and put me to work patching up the actual warriors.

Vala chuckles lightly. Shin raises her voice a little so that it reaches Krellis. He looks over his shoulder at her while she speaks.

SHIN

You're a medic? But you're so...

She gestures up and down at his looming stature. Krellis nods and laughs a little, a proud smile tugging at the corners of his mouth.

KRELLIS

Yep, well. Don't judge by size. I'm really not the fighting type. Had a few years with the Resistance and then...well, a change of scenery but still the same job. That's how I met Vala.

Vala and Krellis share a reminiscent, comfortable smile.

VALA

Because someone decided to run in mid-battle. Even when all the guards tried to stop him.

KRELLIS

(mockingly)

And that someone stopped you bleeding out. Even if it meant they got thrown in the pit for a week.

Vala snorts a laugh.

VALA

Well, of course. You interrupted a very entertaining death. They can't be having that.

Despite the light-hearted, joking tone between the two friends, Shin's eyes and mouth are wide with horror.

SHIN

That's horrible. They want you to die?

Vala looks down at her and shrugs.

VALA
They want a show. They want the
credits that come with the bets.
We're not people to them - just a
part of the game.

Vala walks a little faster, but Shin continues to lag behind. She furrows her brow at the ground as she walks.

18 EXT. FOREST - EARLY MORNING

Jeyin walks besides Krellis, wincing every few moments at the pain in her side. Krellis glances at her, still pushing leaves out of their path as they walk.

KRELLIS
Are you sure you can keep going?

Jeyin grits her teeth and nods. Krellis looks over his shoulder at Vala and Shin chatting behind them.

KRELLIS (cont'd)
You don't want her to know how bad it
is?

Jeyin licks her lips, eyes glued to the ground.

JEYIN
Shin's always been a strong girl.
Always. But I don't want her to have
to be.

Krellis nods, but stays silent.

JEYIN (cont'd)
All I've ever tried to do is protect
her. But she's...different. And when
they came and took us, they nearly
left me behind. Said I was too old to
be any use.
(soft, humourless
laugh)
I guess they decided cleaning up
after people is an ageless job.

She shakes her head.

JEYIN (cont'd)
I didn't care what they did to me.
Being there meant I could make sure
she was safe, but-

Krellis chimes in.

KRELLIS
But none of us were safe there. Not
really.

Jeyin nods, hastily wiping at her eyes.

JEYIN
I don't want her to feel like she has
to look after me. That's not her job.

Krellis looks over at her.

JEYIN (cont'd)
I would put my life on the line a
hundred times over if it meant she
could live a better life.

Krellis stops walking for a moment. He turns to her
properly, eyes deadly serious.

KRELLIS
You won't have to do that. We're all
making it through this.

Jeyin gives him a resigned, doubtful smile. She looks ahead
and continues walking despite the pain.

JEYIN
Whatever the price of freedom for my
daughter, I will gladly pay.

Krellis watches her walk on for a moment before he follows.

19 EXT. FOREST - MERCENARY CAMP - EARLY MORNING

The mercenaries form a semi-circle around Captain Jasu.
Those in front take a knee. Bay stands towards the back,
arms crossed and jaw tense.

CAPTAIN JASU
Listen up. We'll start moving through
the forest. Keep your heads on a
swivel. First sign of the escapees,
signal me. Remember - we're paid,
breathing or not.

Chuckles ripple through the squad; Bay stays stonily silent.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
We get'em-

MERCENARIES
No matter the cost!

Jasu smirks.

CAPTAIN JASU
Let's move out!

The mercenaries stand, slapping each other on the back as they ready their gear.

20 EXT. FOREST - EARLY MORNING

The mercenaries patrol the forest in search of the escapees. They all have their various weapons at the ready. Bay, however, has a weighty rifle slung over his shoulder. Nyx catches up with him.

NYX
Bay, where's your blaster?

Bay rubs the back of his neck.

BAY
Well, I uh. Thought I could use some more firepower.

A few more mercenaries are now walking along beside them. Nyx nudges Bay with his elbow.

NYX
C'mon. You know you've never needed the help. You are the weapon.
(turns to the mercenaries)
Remember that mission on Baatu? This guy took down four guys with his bare hands! He barely had to move!

The rest of the mercenaries chuckle and murmur amongst themselves. Bay smiles tightly. Jasu slows down ahead of them and calls to him.

CAPTAIN JASU
Bay, take the scanner and keep your eyes peeled.

Bay nods and Jasu ploughs ahead, desperately searching the trees for her prey. He looks down at the scanner, moving it back and forth as he surveys the terrain ahead. He swallows, hesitant to find them at all.

The scanner beeps and the mercenaries whip their heads to Bay. He peers closer at the machine's screen to see four outlines of people not too far on the group's right. The mercenaries gather around, Jasu's eyes bright with excitement.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
You found them.

Bay's jaw tightens.

21 EXT. FOREST - MORNING

The escapees rush through the forest. They slow a little. Krellis and Vala look around the forest and into the sky. There is no sound but their breathing and cautious footsteps. Suddenly, a shot from a blaster hits a tree mere millimetres from Krellis' head. He whips around and stares in the direction it came from.

MERCENARY (O.S.)
Over here!

Vala grabs Krellis' arm.

VALA
Move!

She pulls him behind her, with Jeyin close behind with her arm around Shin. They leap into a ditch.

22 EXT. FOREST - DITCH - CONTINUOUS

Shin and the group huddle in a ditch. Jeyin wraps an arm around the young girl, pulling her close.

KRELLIS
What do we do?

Vala steels her eyes.

VALA
We fight our way out.

KRELLIS
(incredulous)
You're kidding. We're completely outnumbered and who knows what kind of firepower they've got.

Vala glares at him, but there's fear in her eyes.

VALA

I don't care. I am not going back.

Krellis softens and places a gentle hand on her arm.

KRELLIS

I won't let you. But we have to be smart about this.

Vala slumps against the dirt and exhales slowly. She nods, sure of herself once again.

VALA

I'll lead them away, then. Give you three a chance to make a break for the trees.

Shin turns to her, eyes wide.

SHIN

You can't! They'll kill you.

KRELLIS

She's right. It's a suicide mission. No - no, absolutely not.

Vala turns to him, a private moment between the two of them. She is unwavering, but kind. She touches his arm.

VALA

It's the only way. My turn to save you.

Krellis looks as if he is going to protest, but he gives a small, short nod. Vala turns back to Shin, who is still looking up at her with wide, watery eyes. Vala leans down and takes a clasp from her tunic.

VALA (cont'd)

(whispers)

You and me - we're not going down without a fight.

Vala presses the clasp into Shin's shaking hands. Shin sits up straighter and looks Vala straight in the eye.

23 EXT. FOREST - MORNING

The mercenaries crouch behind a small ridge, huddling around Captain Jasu.

CAPTAIN JASU
We'll send in a small team, keep them
pinned down. Then the rest of us will
surround them and then-
(wicked grin)
It's pay day.

She turns to Nyx on her left.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
Nyx. You-

The sound of pounding footsteps interrupts her. Everyone's heads whip around. Vala sprints away from the mercenaries, into the woods. The rest of the escapees leap out of the ditch and take off in the opposite direction.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
(hisses)
Blast it.

She turns back to her crew.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
Nyx. Take a squad after that woman.
Get her.

Nyx gives her a sly smile.

NYX
You got it, Cap. No matter the cost.

Nyx nods to a few of the mercenaries and they shoot off after Vala without another word needed. Jasu addresses the others.

CAPTAIN JASU
We'll go after them. You three -
pincer movement. Take them from the
left. Bay - you're with me. We'll
come in from the right. Move out.

The mercenaries nod and separate, heading after their prey.

24 EXT. FOREST - CLEARING - MORNING

Vala bursts into the clearing at the full speed. She screeches to a halt, eyes wild and on edge as she surveys the trees around her. The group of mercenaries emerge from the trees, surrounding her like predators with injured prey. Vala takes her baton off her belt and holds it up, getting into a fighting stance.

There's a glint in her eye; this is her arena now. She charges at one mercenary before they get the chance to all attack at once.

The fight that ensues is messy, but Vala is like a machine. But she is just too outnumbered. The wookiee hauls her off of her feet. She kicks and flails, trying to loosen his grip but to no avail. Nyx pushes himself up from the ground, wipes blood from the corner of his mouth and approaches. There is murderous hatred in his eyes. Vala's eyes dart around, frantic and desperate. She turns to her left and spies the thermal detonators strapped to her captor's chest. She grabs one, but Nyx doesn't notice, only intent on causing her harm.

Once he reaches her, he grabs her hair.

NYX
We're gonna take you back where you
belong-
(spits the word)
Slave.

Vala grits her teeth.

VALA
I am not going back.

She opens her hand. Nyx looks down and sees the red blinking light.

NYX
Oh shi-

CUT TO:

25 EXT. FOREST - MORNING

Krellis, Jeyin and Shin sprint through the trees. An explosion rings out. Krellis stutters to a stop. He whips his head around, eyes wide. The grief is painted all over his face. He knows what has happened.

KRELLIS
(barely a whisper)
No.

Shin and her mother join him.

SHIN
(terrified)
What was that?

She looks up at Krellis, his face a mask of pain.

SHIN (cont'd)
Krellis?

He swallows and covers the pain with stony determination.

KRELLIS
It was Vala giving us a chance.
(deep breath, urgent)
We have to keep going. They're gonna
be right behind us.

Jeyin hunches over, gripping her side. The red stain of blood has grown considerably. Shin drops to Jeyin's side immediately.

SHIN
She just needs a minute. She's hurt.

Krellis is clearly frustrated, but keeps his tone steady.

KRELLIS
Only a few seconds.
(quiet, under his
breath almost)
I've got a bad feeling about this.

A twig snaps in the trees around them and they all spin, on high alert. But no one is there.

SHIN
(softly)
Mother. Can you keep going?

Jeyin's breathing is shaky but she nods weakly. She tries to stand but her knees buckle. Tears start to fall down Shin's face.

SHIN (cont'd)
Please. We have to go.

Jeyin strokes Shin's cheek lightly with a trembling hand.

JEYIN
Oh, my dear Shin. I know you're
scared. But that's a good thing. Look
how strong you are. I wish you didn't
have to be. I wish...that I could
have given you a better life. But you
will be free. I know it. Do not let
fear control you, Shin. You control
it.

Shin cries harder. Krellis stands beside them.

KRELLIS
We have to keep going, or they'll-

A group of mercenaries appear from the trees ahead of them. They smile, blasters ready.

REYA FENN
Well, well, well. Looks like we got to you first.

Shin grasps her mother's arm, eyes wide. Krellis steps in front of them protectively. He squares his shoulders, drawing himself up to his full height.

YASLO BIS
Come on - don't make it worse for yourselves.

Krellis clenches his jaw.

KRELLIS
We're not going with you.

One of the mercenaries nudges another.

YASLO BIS
Looks like we get to do this the fun way.

They laugh meanly. Krellis shakes his head, fed up.

KRELLIS
Is this really how you spend your time? Intimidating and killing people that just want to get on with their lives? To have a life.

A mercenary sneers.

SHADA
That's not our problem.

Despite literally staring down the barrel of the gun, Krellis scoffs.

KRELLIS
Right. Because you just run around hurting people and taking your credits. That's all you care about. Don't you see that there's another way?

He gestures to Shin, who is still cowering next to Jeyin.

KRELLIS (cont'd)
She's just a kid. And you're standing
there pointing blasters at her?

One of the mercenary swallows hard, their weapon wavering a little.

KRELLIS (cont'd)
It doesn't have to be like this. This
doesn't have to be who you are. You
can let us go, let us have the
freedom that everyone deserves. You
have that power. So please just-

Krellis stops suddenly. We pull back through a hole in his head to find Captain Jasu standing beside him, her blaster still glowing. She smiles wickedly as Krellis crumples to the floor.

SHIN
(distraught)
No!

Bay stands slightly behind Jasu. His eyes lock on Shin, and hers on him. Her grief and shock flood her, but there is something else - a recognition, a feeling she doesn't recognise, as she holds Bay's gaze.

Jasu holsters her blaster, unfazed. Shin gets to her feet, fists clenched despite their trembling. She glares at Jasu, but the captain just laughs.

CAPTAIN JASU
What are you doing, little girl? Hm?
Want to fight me?

She turns to Bay.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
Reckon we should put the old woman
out of her misery first?

Bay hasn't taken his eyes off of Shin this whole time. Jasu takes this as hesitation to kill someone so young. She rolls her eyes. She whistles sharply and the beast darts forward. It lands on top of Jeyin, scratching with its thick claws and snapping at her flesh. Jeyin screams. Shin is frozen, forced to just watch.

Jasu whistles again and the beast leaps off and returns to its master's side. Shin drops to her knees beside Jeyin. The injuries the older woman has sustained are awful.

She only has a few moments before she bleeds out. Shin grasps her mother's hand.

SHIN

Please. No. You can't go. Please.

Jeyin licks her dry lips. Her voice is weak, barely audible.

JEYIN

Shin. It's alright.

(shaky breath)

You...control...it.

With one last rattled breath, Jeyin closes her eyes and her grip on Shin's hand loosens.

SHIN

(to herself)

No. No. Mother, please. Come back. I--
I--

She looks up at the mercenaries surrounding her. Their weapons have dropped a little, not seeing her as a threat. Shin releases a guttural scream and a shimmering shock wave explodes out from her. The mercenaries are flung back, getting tangled in branches and dropping to the ground, unconscious. Bay, however, is only pushed to one knee and backwards a few feet. His rifle is flung out of his hands, smashing against the ground. The beast jumps in front of Jasu, absorbing most of the impact. The captain still flies backwards, but rolls to her hands and knees, out of breath.

Shin stops screaming, breathing heavy. Her eyes are wide, unsure how she did that. Bay stands and takes a few steps towards the young girl. Shin scrambles back, frightened. Bay stops, examining her.

BAYLAN

You - you're-

Jasu hauls herself up. Fury flares in her eyes. She stalks towards Shin and raises her blaster. A vicious smile forms on her lips.

CAPTAIN JASU

Looks like you'll be worth even more now. A Force sensitive kid should be worth at least double. Right, Bay?

She looks over her shoulder to see Bay with his eyes locked on Shin.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)

Bay?

He tears his gaze away. Jasu looks at him expectantly.

CAPTAIN JASU (cont'd)
What's wrong with you?

BAYLAN
(voice quiet, stony)
We're not doing this. We're not
taking her back.

Jasu laughs, thinking it's a joke. But she then sees the
look in his eyes.

CAPTAIN JASU
I knew there was something off with
you. You've gone soft.

Bay's nostrils flare.

BAYLAN
No. I'm just done playing the good
soldier. And I'm not letting you do
this.

Jasu barks another mean laugh.

CAPTAIN JASU
And what - you're gonna stop me?
Without a blaster?

Bay looks at her, a small, spiteful smile beginning to
form...

BAY
I don't need one.

He takes something from under his jacket. With a 'schwoom',
a yellow lightsaber blade grows, throwing shadows across
Bay's serious, defiant expression. Jasu signals for her
beast, and it stands at her side. She whistles and nods at
Bay, a smug look on her face. Bay locks eyes with the beast
and something passes between them. He nods towards the
woods, and the pet turns and runs away. Jasu, filled with
confusion and rage, charges at Bay.

The fight that ensues is fast-paced, with numerous close-
calls for both of them. A blaster fires from behind them
and, without looking, Bay deflects it from his lightsaber.
It hits Jasu in the chest, and she falls to the ground,
unmoving.

Nyx stands on the edge of the clearing, rifle raised and
breathing heavy. His clothes are tattered and singed.

Blood runs down the side of his face. He surveys the scene around him: the mercenaries unmoving on the ground, Jeyin and Krellis' bodies, a shaking Shin, and Baylan standing over it all.

NYX

Bay - what...what happened?

Bay tears his eyes away from Shin. He swallows hard. Shin looks at Nyx, eyes wide as she scans him.

SHIN

Vala...What happened to her?

Nyx wrinkles his nose at her, rifle aimed right between her eyes.

NYX

That slave set off a grenade. Killed my whole squad.

(sneers)

And herself.

A sob rips through Shin's throat.

NYX (cont'd)

Looks like you're the only one left.
May as well make it a clean sweep.

He takes a step towards Shin. Bay grabs the muzzle of his weapon and drags it down, forcing Nyx to spin and face him.

NYX (cont'd)

What are you doing?

BAY

You're not touching her.

Nyx, confused, scoffs a laugh.

NYX

Want to do the honours, do you?

Bay shakes his head.

BAY

It's over, Nyx. We're done.

NYX

What are you talking about? We have to at least take her back with us. She must be worth something. Come on -

Bay cuts him off, stern and determined.

BAY

No. I'm out. I'm taking her with me,
and you're gonna let us leave.

Nyx drops his rifle to his side.

NYX

What are you doing? This isn't you.
This isn't how we do things, Bay.
We're in this together - you and me.
Like we have been for years.

Bay throws his hands up, fed up.

BAY

That was never me. You don't
understand. I had my life ripped from
me. Twice.

Full of emotions, Bay balls his fists and thrusts them
towards the ground. Leaves and dirt fly back, pushed by the
Force. Nyx takes quick steps backwards. His eyes are wide.

NYX

(stammers)

You're...you're a Jedi.

Bay takes a deep breath as he steadies himself.

BAY

I...am no Jedi. But- I was. It was-
(taps his chest, hard)
Instilled in me. But then it died.
They all died. I saw it happen. And
it nearly killed me too. So I gave
up.

He gestures towards Nyx, who just stands there, shaking his
head as he takes it all in.

BAY (cont'd)

I was never one of you. I was just...
waiting.

Nyx's voice is uncertain.

NYX

But we - we're a family.

BAY

I don't get to have a family. I never
have. They're always taken from me.

(MORE)

BAY (cont'd)
But this time is going to be...
different.

NYX
What are you talking about?

BAY
This. All of this. Being a pawn for
people like the Jedi, the Hutts, like
Jasu.

NYX
That's the job, Bay.

BAY
And I'm done! I'm out.

NYX
What's changed, huh?

Bay looks over at Shin, who is still cowering next to her
mother's body. She locks eyes with him.

BAY
Her.

Nyx laughs.

NYX
Her? Really? That's why you're gonna
betray who you are? Betray us?!

Bay squares his shoulders, defiant. Nyx's nostrils flare and
he sneers.

NYX (cont'd)
That's not how this works, Bay.

He pulls out his knife and stalks towards Shin. She
scrambles backwards. Nyx raises his blade. She squeezes her
eyes shut and raises her hands over her face to shield
herself. Nyx stops in his tracks. Shin puts her hands down,
opening her eyes slowly.

Nyx's face is slack. His knife drops from his hand. He looks
down. The tip of Bay's lightsaber protrudes from his chest.
Bay pulls it out. It is a darker colour now, more orange
than yellow. Nyx drops to the floor, his face growing paler
by the second. Bay kneels beside him as he turns off his
weapon.

NYX (cont'd)
(weak)
Bay...

Bay tenses his jaw.

BAY
My name. Is Baylan Skoll.

Nyx takes his final, shaky breath.

BAY (cont'd)
(under his breath)
No matter the cost.

Baylan turns to Shin. She is shocked, taken aback, but not completely frightened...

BAY (cont'd)
It's okay. You're safe. You're safe
now.

Shin's eyes are still wide as she tries to take everything in.

SHIN
We're...we're the same?

Baylan gives her a small smile.

BAY
We are. I've been where you are -
making things happen with just a
thought, not knowing how. It's scary
and can make you feel...so alone.

Shin purses her lips. A swell of emotion overtakes her, but she holds back the wave. Bay leans in closer.

BAY (cont'd)
But neither of us ever have to be
alone again. I can teach you, train
you. We can bring this cycle of - of
hurt to end.

The unconscious mercenaries begin to stir. Bay looks around, eyes urgent and imploring now.

BAY (cont'd)
But we have to go now. What do you
say? Don't you think you've earned
your freedom?

He holds out his hand. Shin looks back at her mother's body, and then around at the mercenaries scattered in the clearing. But then, she looks back to Baylan. There's hope in her eyes, as if she's seeing the future she can finally have. The one her mother had hoped for her.

She takes Baylan's hand. He pulls her up to her feet and powers up his lightsaber again. Shin stares at it in awe.

The mercenaries start getting to their feet. Baylan looks down at Shin.

BAY (cont'd)

I have to take care of this first.

He whirls into battle, cutting down his ex-comrades in a flurry of light and screams. Shin, watching at first, scrunches her eyes shut. But, unable to stop herself, she slowly opens one of her eyes to see Baylan, an unstoppable force.

With all of the mercenaries dead, Baylan returns to her side. He's barely broken a sweat.

BAY (cont'd)

Ready?

Shin looks over at Jasu's body. She walks over to it, eyes boiling over with hatred. She leans down and rips a piece of her armour off, holding it tight in her hand. She turns back to Bay, standing a little taller. She's not a scared little girl anymore.

SHIN

Ready.

Bay smiles at and together, they run off into the trees, towards the still-swirling column of smoke from the ship crashing.

FADE TO BLACK.